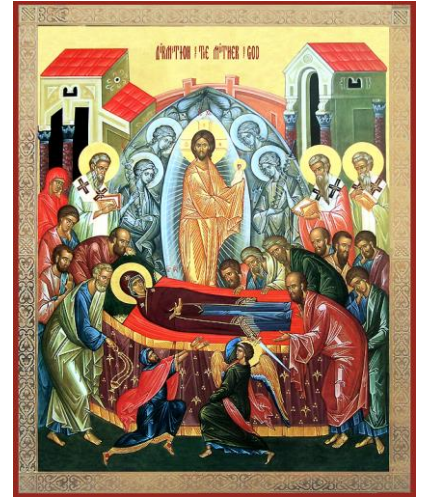


A Pastoral Letter on the Dormition of the Theotokos.

Aug 15/28 2018

In the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit. My intention and ambition is to write a pastoral letter before all of the Great Feasts. It is an opportunity for me to say some theological things that we all should know, but also to share with you from my heart.

Today is the glorious Dormition of our all holy lady, the Theotokos. This is the last feast of the church year, and in context with the Transfiguration, which we just finished celebrating (Aug 6/19¹, and the festal period extends for an entire week, ending just before Dormition), it tells us about our future. At the very end of the church year, since September 1 is the “Indiction”, the beginning of the church year, we have these two feasts almost on top of each other. Let’s look at both of them together, and see how they promise what our future will be. This future was secured by the resurrection.



http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/fv_2018+dormition-pastoral-letter.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/fv_2018+dormition-pastoral-letter.pdf

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/Xi9LalsJVtk> (very similar to the text)

Contents

Meaning of the Transfiguration	1
Explaining the Dormition.....	2
Meaning of the Transfiguration and Dormition together	3
Two feelings that we must have in the Christian life in order to save our souls.	3
If you love, you pray – period.	3
How to pray for people in the church services.	3
A note about Commemoration slips. You MUST pray also!.....	4
How to pray for people DURING the Divine Liturgy.....	4
The Gospel Read on Feast of the Theotokos - Luke 10:38-42; 11:27-28	4
Why do we venerate the Theotokos so highly? Because of her behavior.....	4

Meaning of the Transfiguration

In the Transfiguration we see that the three closest disciples of Jesus went up with Jesus to Mount Tabor, and He showed them how He really is. According to the Fathers, Jesus did not reveal the full intensity of the divine light that is always streaming from Him, because they weren’t ready even for the small amount of what He showed them. He basically lifted the veil and showed them that they in the flesh could see the divine light of God; this is the uncreated light of God, His energy. That energy is always present, but most of us cannot see it because of our ignorance and our sins. I think of this many times when I’m serving the Divine liturgy and I look in the altar and see shadows. In the next life there will be no shadow, only light. There will be no ignorance and doubt and passions and turmoil. There will just be light. In this world, there is also always

darkness with the light, even during the Divine liturgy. If we were completely illuminated, during the Divine liturgy we would see such light that we wouldn't even be aware of the terrestrial light and would see no shadow. That is what's happening but not what we see. We should always remember this, and long to be where there is only light of God.

The Transfiguration showed that we can partake of God, be part of God, and be united with God in the flesh. This is an application, shall we say, of the resurrection. The resurrection is the promise; yes, Jesus Christ has conquered death for us, but what does "conquering death" mean? Conquering death means that in the flesh, we can behold the light of God and be completely at peace, completely full of grace, and completely united with God. This is called "Theosis", and it is the purpose of our life and the sole goal of the incarnation and the Christian life that we live.

Explaining the Dormition

Then right after the Transfiguration, we have the Dormition. This word means "falling asleep". The Mother of God fell asleep, that is she died just like all flesh dies. Even our Lord Jesus Christ, the God-man, died. Flesh dies, until it no longer needs to die. The Mother of God knew of her upcoming death, and wanted the apostles to be with her in her last hours. She got word to them to come to see her in Jerusalem. They came from far and near. Some of the ones that came from far away came on clouds. If that seems too fantastic to you, then I submit to you that you must think the Eucharist is too fantastic – when the wine and bread become the body and blood of Jesus Christ, or that flesh which when it is put in the soil and corrupts immediately can be reinvigorated and have life in the divine light of God. If you believe those things, then it is certainly easy enough to believe that the apostles could have come to the Theotokos on clouds.

She knew them all very well. She lived about 30 years after the resurrection. She was a mentor to them and a mother to them, especially to John, but really to all of them. Remember that the holy apostle John was just a kid when the crucifixion occurred, perhaps a lad of about 15. The Lord, while on the cross, commended her to him and he to her; he took care of her, but she also took care of him². Her grace and her personality permeate the church. It does this in a marvelous way because we don't have any treatises from the Theotokos. We don't even know if she wrote anything down. We know very little of what she said, and yet her character is in the church, more than any other mortal human being. How do we know this? By experience. The church knows that and we can know it also, even if we are sinners, by experience. I invite you to cultivate that experience so that you would know what the mind of the church is. In lieu of our personal experience, if we are humble, we read things from holy people in the church and believe their experiences. In our modern age, people depend upon their own experiences and their own knowledge, and sometimes they're not even aware of their deep ignorance. This is not the way in the church. We look to the writings of those who "fought the good fight and finished the course"³ as a sure guide for us. When you read the fathers, don't just look for theological truths, but look for a way to modify the way you think and live. That is the greatest benefit of reading the Scripture or the Holy Fathers. We must adjust how we live based upon what we read.

On most feast days of the Theotokos, such as Dormition, we hear the epistle about the incarnation from Philippians, about "letting this mind be in you"⁴. The mind it is speaking of is the mind of the church. The mind of the church is not just the mind of Jesus Christ, but also those whom He loves - those who have become like Him and think like Him. The greatest human (only) contributor to this mind is the Theotokos.

When the Theotokos died all the Apostles were there, save Thomas. They buried her, and then he arrived from India three days later. He wanted very much to see her one last time even if she had already reposed, so they opened the tomb, and she was gone. Jesus Christ had come to take his mother, body and soul, into heaven. The Apostles all learned this from a vision.

The West has this idea of the "Assumption of Mary", were somehow, without her body dying, she jetted up to heaven. That's not true. She died, like any other human being, because she was subject to death just like any other human being, and then our Lord Jesus Christ, because He loves his mother, and He certainly has the right to give his mother any special privileges He wishes since He is God, came down to bring her body and soul together to heaven. She is the only human being other than Jesus Christ who has died and is in heaven, body and soul. Of course, Enoch and Elijah were taken up to heaven, but they did not die.

If you look at the icon of the Dormition, you see Jesus holding a little baby that looks like the Theotokos. She appears to be in a winding sheet, which is a sign that she indeed died. Note that in icons of the Theotokos with her son as an infant, He appears to be in winding sheet which is forecasting that He would die, so that we could have life. The first fulfillment of that promise for a mortal human being was when the Lord brought His mother, after her death, body and soul, to heaven.

Meaning of the Transfiguration and Dormition together

Do you understand how these two feasts together tell us our future? All of us, or at least most of us, are destined to die physically in the flesh (the only way any of us would escape bodily death is if our Lord comes before we die – see the description in the fourth chapter of first Thessalonians⁵). We also are destined, if we struggle to follow the commandments, to be alive in the flesh, and to be in the heavenly places with our Savior and behold His divine uncreated light. That's what these two feasts together are telling us. The feast of the Ascension, when Christ ascended bodily into heaven (always celebrated 40 days after Pascha on Thursday) was a promise that we would ascend, and the Lord's taking of His mother into heaven is the first fulfillment of that promise.

For the life of me, I cannot figure out why, if we know this future, we still do the things we do. I speak for myself first. I really don't know why do some the things I do and why I don't do some the things that I don't do. Of course, the apostle Paul talked of this conundrum; it is part of the human condition⁶. Our strange behavior comes out of our sinful condition that sometimes feels like chains that are keeping us from being free - they keep me from praying with attention, or feeling the love of God or having the vivaciousness that we should have as Christians.

Two feelings that we must have in the Christian life in order to save our souls.

I was talking to someone recently, about the two feelings that we must have in the Christian life in order to save our souls. One is grief and mourning, sadness. The other is joy. We cannot have joy without mourning. Grief or mourning is not an emotional feeling; it is a deep existential feeling in our soul because we are far from what we should be, and those we love in the world are also far from what they should be. There should be a deep pain in you because things are not as they should be. This pain is one of the greatest motivators to teach us to truly pray with our heart and to live according to our heart. Those who learn to pray with their heart and live in a spiritual way will certainly be rewarded with joy.

The Mother of God certainly experienced terrible grief. There was a sword that pierced her heart when her Savior and son was crucified⁷. This sword was not just experienced because her son was put on the cross. It was because she had love for all the world. The church has love for all the world. Experiencing grief, and acting upon that grief is one of the great legacies that the Mother of God has given to us.

If you love, you pray – period.

I want to make a parenthetical comment here, because sometimes people hear teaching from various places that is overly strict and legalistic and not according to love. If you love, you pray – period. It doesn't matter whom you love. It could be someone in the church, someone that you consider to be saintly, or someone who has apostatized, or has never been in the church or is an atheist, or has committed any sin, including suicide. It matters not. That is completely unimportant, as to whether or not you would pray for them. The mind of the church is to love all. God's judgment is His own, and we should make no predictions regarding anybody. If we have love, we will have the mind of church and we will love everyone and pray especially for those people that cross our path. This is a critically important thing to do. If we do not pray for those who cross our path and feel grief over their griefs and falls, that we cannot really call ourselves Christians.

How to pray for people in the church services.

We should follow the church's traditions regarding praying for people in church services. If a person is a baptized Orthodox Christian we should pray for them as an Orthodox Christian. If a person is not an Orthodox Christian, then there are appropriate ways to pray for them in the church. It is not our tradition to commemorate non-Orthodox reposed in our requiem services⁸, but we will pray for non-Orthodox living in supplicatory prayer services. We should never ask the priest to commemorate non-Orthodox, living or dead in the Proskimdie (this is a preparation service that occurs before the Divine

liturgy, in the altar), but most priests will gladly pray for anyone during the Proskimide. I certainly will. We will take a particle of bread out of the prosphora we are using and put it on the diskos when we commemorate Orthodox people, living or dead. If a person is not Orthodox, then we pray for them without taking out a particle. It is important that commemoration slips clearly tell the priest who is Orthodox and who is not. The reason we do not commemorate with a particle of bread those who are not Orthodox is because those particles will later be put into the chalice at the end of the liturgy, when it contains the body and blood of Christ. It would not be correct to allow non-Orthodox to have communion, nor would it be correct to assume that they would even want communion, so for both reasons we do not commemorate them with a particle of bread.

A note about Commemoration slips. You MUST pray also!

I want to tell you one more important thing about the commemoration slips that are submitted to the priest before liturgy. You must also pray for these people. Do not fall into the lazy trap of creating commemoration list and then forgetting about those people. Prayer for others should benefit them and us. If you only submit names and then forget about the people, there is no benefit to your soul. The priest has a sacred task. He is to pray for the people and with the people, but by no means is he to pray instead of the people.

How to pray for people DURING the Divine Liturgy

How should you pray for people you love during the Divine liturgy? Certainly, you should be praying mentally in your heart during the Divine liturgy for those that you care about, at any time you're able. It is very important to cultivate this prayer. The Jesus prayer is the most immediately accessible prayer for mental prayer during the Divine liturgy. The Divine liturgy is *never* something that we experience passively. We must be actively praying during the Divine liturgy at every moment. Some of those moments we will be singing or listening to the prayers being sung, but there are many moments that we can be praying internally. We must struggle to do this, or else we really aren't benefiting from the Divine liturgy as we should. If you're not good at praying continuously, do not despair. You will get better if you try. You absolutely will never get better if you do not try.

The Gospel Read on Feast of the Theotokos - Luke 10:38-42; 11:27-28

Let's look at the composite reading that is read on all of her feasts. It is really peculiar reading because it is from two places in the Scripture that are not related to each other⁹. The church has decided to put them together. One is when Jesus was at dinner with Mary, Martha and Lazarus. They all loved Him very much and he would come to stay with him very often in Bethany. Martha is busy serving and Mary is just sitting at His feet and listening to His teaching. Of course, this "Mary" was not the Theotokos, but someone with the same name. Martha wanted Jesus to rebuke Mary, and He tells her that Mary has chosen "that good part". We must also choose that good part. Everything we do in life and the things that we value and the attitudes that we have are all making a choice – to either choose the good part or something else. This is the most important reason why we venerate Mary and have such great veneration for her, because she chose the good part.

The last part of this reading jumps to the following incident: "And it came to pass, as he spake these things, a certain woman of the company lifted up her voice, and said unto him, Blessed is the womb that bare thee, and the paps which thou hast sucked. 28 But he said, Yea rather, blessed are they that hear the word of God, and keep it"¹⁰ In order to understand these verses, you must know that the Lord was using an idiom when he said "Yea rather". A rough way to translate this idiom would be: "Yes, but also". Sometimes people who have not been raised to love and venerate the mother of God will take this verse as evidence that she is not important. They are succumbing to a translation error which only compounds their theological error. The Lord was *agreeing* that his mother was blessed, and He was emphasizing the reason for her blessedness. She heard the word of God and kept it.

Why do we venerate the Theotokos so highly? Because of her behavior.

We believe that when the Archangel Gabriel told her that the Holy Spirit would overshadow her, and because of her word, that is her obedience and her statement to Gabriel: "Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy

word”, then indeed at that moment she became pregnant with the God-man, Jesus Christ, and by grace she entered into “Theosis”. Theosis is when we enter into union with God. It is the ultimate purpose of our life.

Her pregnancy proceeded as all pregnancies do, but her birth was without travail. Jesus was born without breaking the seal of her virginity. We believe and teach that she was a virgin before birth, during birth¹¹, and after birth. If these things are hard to accept, that I refer you to the Eucharist and to the resurrection.

Mary lived with great personal purity from the time she was a child. This is her personal choice. During her pregnancy, she became even more pure because Jesus Christ within her enlightened her. We should cultivate this desire – to have Jesus Christ within enlightening us. We should try to choose the good part. If you would keep a diary of what you do during the day you might be really shocked at how much time you spent looking at screens, or eating, or reading magazines, or gossiping, or doing other such things rather than praying or doing spiritual things. The Theotokos only did spiritual things. She didn’t supernaturally know everything; the Gospel shows clearly that there were things that she was ignorant about. Even when we are united to God, we grow in knowledge.

The future is before you today, if you choose to live according to it. We have the promise of the resurrection, and in the resurrection we will in the flesh with Jesus Christ, and be able to behold His divine light. All that remains for us is to live according to this Promise. Through the prayers of the holy Theotokos, O Jesus Christ our God, have mercy on us and save us. Amen.

http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/fv_2018+dormition-pastoral-letter.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/fv_2018+dormition-pastoral-letter.pdf

¹ When two days are shown, it means that the person giving the date follows the old calendar and generally the church date is given first and then the secular calendar date. I have called that calendar: “Joe’s garage calendar”, because it would be the calendar that would hang on the wall in Joe’s garage or any place of business. Those who use the new calendar to decide when Orthodox feasts are have no difference in their dates. The Julian calendar currently is 13 days behind the Gregorian calendar. Therefore, Transfiguration, which in our books is on August 6, on the secular calendar is August 6 +13 equals August 19. Likewise, Dormition is on August 15 according to our books, which in the secular calendar would be 15+13 equals August 28. These kinds of calculations are easy, but they present a challenge to us who cannot remember how many days are in each month. For instance, the Nativity of Christ is as everybody knows, December 25. That’s the church date. If we want to know the day that it is in the Gregorian calendar we have to add 13 and remember that December has 31 days. Therefore, Orthodox Nativity, for those who use the Julian calendar is on January 7 on Joe’s garage calendar. For these examples the dates would be written down as August 6/19, August 15/28 and December 25/January 7.

² John 19:26-27 “When Jesus therefore saw his mother, and the disciple standing by, whom he loved, he saith unto his mother, Woman, behold thy son! (27) Then saith he to the disciple, Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home.”

³ 2 Timothy 4:6-8 “For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand. (7) I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: (8) Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing.”

⁴ Philippians 2:5-11 Philippians 2:3: “Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus:”

⁵ 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 “But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. (14) For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. (15) For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep. (16) For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: (17) Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. (18) Wherefore comfort one another with these words.”

⁶ Romans 7:14-15 KJV “For we know that the law is spiritual: but I am carnal, sold under sin. (15) For that which I do I allow not: for what I would, that do I not; but what I hate, that do I.”

⁷ Luke 2:34-35 KJV And Simeon blessed them, and said unto Mary his mother, Behold, this child is set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel; and for a sign which shall be spoken against; (35) (Yea, a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also,) that the thoughts of many hearts may be revealed.

⁸ Some people will make a snap decision that the church’s refusal to pray for non-Orthodox in public Requiem services is cruel, but they are misunderstanding two important things. The first is that everyone is always free to pray for anyone they wish as much as they wish. We never depend on only the church to do our praying. The other is that it is incorrect to assume that a person who’d died not being in the Orthodox Church wants to be considered to be Orthodox. When we commemorate someone in a public Requiem service, we are also stating that person is Orthodox. That would be inappropriate for someone who was not stated that they are Orthodox. They have free will, and we respect it.

⁹ Luke 10:38-42; 11:27-28

¹⁰ Luke 11:27-28

¹¹ The beginning of the troparion for the Dormition makes this very clear: “In giving birth thou didst preserve thy virginity...”